

The page which follows this has been quoted already (p. 288 f.). The importance of Prof. Bousset's views on the subject is so great that I make no apology for completing my transcript of his summary. He proceeds in conclusion (p. 550):

One point, however, must be emphasised very specially here. Judaism came in contact with Persian religion, as we have already explained, primarily in Babylon. We shall have to conclude, therefore, that the Jews learnt to know this religion not in its purity but when strongly tainted with Babylonian elements. This mixture of Babylonian and Persian religion must in general be regarded among the most important facts of the history of religious syncretism during the last centuries B.C. It must also have been highly significant for the development of Judaism. We must also conclude that Babylonian religion in many respects influenced that of the Jews through the medium of Parsism, even where a direct contact is not admissible. The origin of many ideas which were influential in Judaism cannot accordingly be defined with certainty; and we must be content to speak ultimately in general terms of "foreign Oriental elements."

The admission of Prof. Bousset that Parsi influence on Judaism must be restricted to the period of syncretism and decadence in Parsism has very great significance for our problem. Practically it means that Zarathushtra himself is to be struck out of the list of the prophets who contributed to the development of Israel's religion. All the indications gathered during the course of these Lectures have converged upon a proof that Zarathushtra influenced only a small circle in the West during the period to which I am limiting my inquiry. What was known of his teaching reached the people living in Babylonia and